

Creative Sound Blaster External USB Sound System

PC Boom-box

Creative has come out with yet another external USB sound device. It is targeted at laptop, as well as desktop users, who want a quick sound upgrade to be done quickly and simply. This small device comes with a clip and Velcro straps allowing easy attachment of the device to your laptop or desktop. Other accessories include a USB cable and a Y-splitter cable.



The sound chip of this device supports EAX, which provides enhanced environmental sound effects. It has audio line-in ports; for connecting to external audio players such as MP3 players, cassette players and audio line-out; for connecting to a 2.1 speaker system. It supports high-end 5.1 and 6.1 speaker systems via an optical-out port. It also has an

Price: Rs 4,299
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Web site: www.soundblaster.com

optical-in port to connect external players. It also supports microphones and headphones, and has its own volume control. The product comes with an installation CD that contains drivers and Creative Media Source software, which can be used for enhancing your music experience. The software lets you control virtual surround and a 10-band graphics equalizer with bass boost. Setting up the sound card is as simple as connecting the USB cable and installing the driver.

We tried some Indian and western music on this sound card, and it showed mediocre performance throughout our tests.

SPECIFICATIONS

USB 1.1 interface, (all jacks are gold plated) Analog line out, Head phone output, SPDIF Optical output, Analog-Digital output selector, MIC input.

Creative Sound Blaster External USB Sound System	
Performance	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Features	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Value for money	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Ease of use	■ ■ ■ ■ ■

WinTasks 4 Professional

Ask the task manager

Without efficient resource and task management, a lot of your hardware bucks may go down the drain. WinTasks 4 Professional allows you to control the potential of your computer's resources.

WinTasks makes it easy to find and



remove unnecessary background processes, and to assign resources to higher-priority tasks. The statistics window shows you the CPU usage and how the internal memory is used. Buttons allow you to stop, increase or decrease the priority level of processes. You can

get a description of the processes, and the DLLs that they use; launch scripts; view CPU and memory usage statistics; record program logs; and enable, disable, add or remove programs from the registry.

The Event log window automatically logs information about all the programs that were run. You can save this information in a file for later analysis. Using the 'built-

Price: Professional: Rs 1,997.50, Upgrade: Rs 1,250, Standard: Rs 1,497.50, Elements: Rs 997.50 per license for 100 or more licenses.
Contact: Liutilities
E-mail: contact@liutilities.com
Web site: www.liutilities.com

WinBackup

An easy to use backup utility

This utility has a nice interface that is made intuitively with easy to understand icons, names and tool tips. The interface is neatly divided into two sections, which consist of data backup and data restore. It has a flexible file and folder selection window, similar to Windows Explorer, and supports various storage media for backing up data-you can use your CD-Writer for efficient back up. It even allows CD-backups to be done automatically at scheduled intervals.

You can use wizards to select the files for backup, and specify the storage destination. The back up process always runs in the background, so that it does not interfere with the normal functioning of your system.

Price: Rs 1,840 (approx) for single user license
Contact: Liutilities
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Web site: www.liutilities.com

in script', you can create functions to automate handling of processes and resources.

The lack of support for Windows Me, and the fact that the CPU and Memory usage is not available for Windows 98, was disappointing.

Overall, priced at Rs1,997, WinTasks 4 is well worth it.

SPECIFICATIONS

Pentium 200 MHz or higher; Windows 98/NT/2000/XP; 10MB hard disk space; 32 MB RAM; 4X CD-ROM Drive

WinTasks 4 Professional	
Performance	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Ease of Use	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Value for money	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Features	■ ■ ■ ■ ■

The restoration of a backup file can also be done easily. Just select the backup file and give the location for restoration. The compression and decompression of the files during these processes are done on the fly, so that maximum performance is gained. It also supports the scheduling of various backup processes.

Backup files can be spanned to more than one CD, so that large files can be backed up. You can also encrypt the backup files using 128 or 256-

SPECIFICATIONS

Pentium class processor at 233 or higher, 32 MB RAM and 64 MB for Windows 2000 and XP, Windows 95, 98, NT, 2000, or XP

WinBackup	
Performance	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Features	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Value for money	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Ease of use	■ ■ ■ ■ ■